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ARTICLE

The Kathryn Krick Controversy Is A Warning To The Entire Church



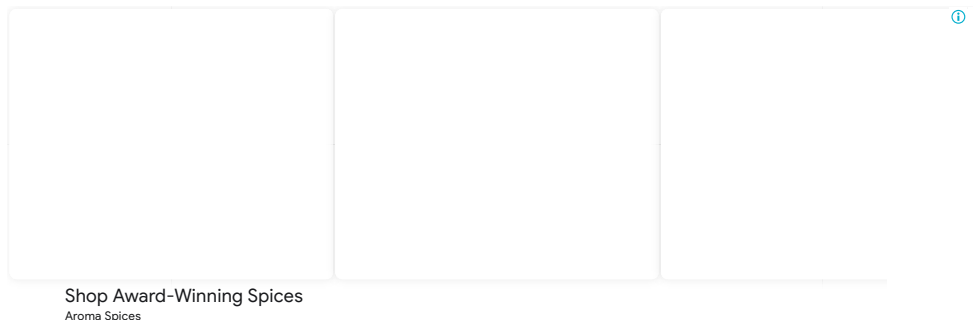
BY PNW STAFF JULY 29, 2026

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The church must never become so skeptical that it dismisses everything supernatural--or so spiritually undiscerning that it accepts everything supernatural.

Scripture commands believers, "Do not quench the Spirit." Yet the very next instruction is equally important: "Test everything; hold fast what is good" (1 Thessalonians 5:19-21). Those commands belong together. Christians are not asked to choose between openness and discernment. We are commanded to practice both.



Although this examination centers on Kathryn Krick, the questions it raises extend far beyond one minister, one church or one branch of Christianity. Every believer is responsible for carefully examining the spiritual leadership under which he or she sits.

The same biblical standards must be applied to pastors, prophets, teachers, evangelists, online personalities and ministry movements--whether they are charismatic, Reformed, Baptist, Pentecostal, independent or part of a historic denomination. No tradition, title, personality or ministry success places a leader beyond biblical scrutiny.

This is especially important in an age when social media can transform a relatively unknown minister into an international spiritual authority almost overnight. Millions of views, packed gatherings, emotional testimonies and devoted followers may demonstrate influence, but they do not necessarily demonstrate God's approval.

Nor are doctrinal error, financial manipulation or unhealthy spiritual control limited to ministries where unusual manifestations of the spirit occur. They can also appear behind polished pulpits, respected institutions and the language of theological orthodoxy. The larger issue is whether Christ remains central, Scripture remains supreme, leaders remain accountable and believers are being directed toward dependence upon God rather than dependence upon a human personality.

That balance is urgently needed in the growing controversy surrounding Kathryn Krick, the Los Angeles leader of Five-Fold Church, commonly called 5F Church.

Krick describes herself as an apostle and leads a ministry centered heavily on healing, deliverance and imparting what she calls "the anointing." Her church says it has been commissioned to heal the sick, cast out demons, raise the dead and equip believers to become powerful vessels of God.

Recent scrutiny intensified after videos from an Ignite Revival book signing in Houston showed people falling, trembling and convulsing as they approached Krick. Krick celebrated the gathering as an outbreak of revival, while critics questioned whether the dramatic reactions represented the Holy Spirit, demonic deliverance, emotional suggestion or something else entirely.

Some critics have moved quickly to label Krick a "cult leader." That term is serious and should not be thrown around merely because a church is charismatic, unconventional or emotionally expressive. Yet avoiding careless labels does not mean ignoring legitimate warning signs.

The more important question is not whether a gathering looks unusual. It is whether the theology, methods, leadership culture and fruit can withstand careful biblical examination.

Physical Manifestations Prove Very Little By Themselves

The Bible does record dramatic physical reactions during encounters with God.

Daniel lost his strength and fell before an angelic messenger. John fell as though dead when confronted by the glorified Christ. At Pentecost, observers believed the disciples were drunk. Scripture also describes people trembling in God's presence.

Christians therefore should be cautious about declaring that falling, shaking or crying can never accompany a genuine spiritual encounter.

But the opposite mistake is equally dangerous. A dramatic physical response does not prove that the Holy Spirit is responsible.

Convulsions also appear in Scripture in connection with demonic oppression. Strong emotions can be intensified by crowd expectations, music, suggestion and the presence of a highly admired leader. People may respond sincerely while still misunderstanding what is happening to them.

The New Testament never presents falling, shaking or losing bodily control as the primary evidence that the Holy Spirit is moving. The clearest evidence is spiritual fruit: repentance, truth, holiness, love, humility, self-control and an exaltation of Jesus Christ.

Paul's instructions concerning spiritual manifestations are especially relevant. Worship is to be conducted "decently and in order," and "the spirits of prophets are subject to prophets" (1 Corinthians 14:32, 40). Whatever else the Spirit may do, the fruit of the Spirit includes self-control.

That does not mean every unusual response is false. It means the response itself cannot be the test.

What Does It Mean To Be An "Apostle"?

Krick's repeated use of the title "Apostle Kathryn" raises another important question.

Christians disagree over whether the word *apostle* can still be used today. Some understand it exclusively as a reference to the foundational apostles personally commissioned by the risen Christ. Others believe Ephesians 4 allows for a continuing, non-foundational apostolic role involving missionary leadership, church planting and spiritual oversight.

Krick argues that apostles and prophets remain necessary because Ephesians 4 says the five ministry gifts will continue until the church reaches maturity.

Even Christians who accept some form of contemporary apostolic ministry, however, should recognize an essential distinction. No modern leader possesses the authority of Peter, John or Paul. No contemporary revelation can add to Scripture, override Scripture or become binding upon the universal church.

The concern is therefore larger than terminology. What authority does the title communicate? Can the leader's teachings be openly questioned? Is she accountable to a genuine plurality of elders? Can followers disagree without being portrayed as rebellious, jealous, spiritually blind or opposed to revival?

A title becomes dangerous when it insulates a leader from correction.

The Bereans were praised for examining even Paul's teaching against Scripture. If the ministry of an authentic biblical apostle could be tested, every modern minister must welcome the same scrutiny.



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Deliverance Must Not Become Spectacle

The New Testament clearly affirms the reality of spiritual evil. Jesus cast out demons, and the early church confronted demonic oppression. Christians should not dismiss spiritual warfare simply because modern Western culture finds it embarrassing.

But biblical deliverance centers on the authority of Christ--not on prolonged performances, viral moments or the personality of the minister.

Critics have questioned videos in which deliverance appears theatrical, continues for extended periods or involves people who reportedly appear in multiple deliverance clips. They argue that these patterns differ from the clear and decisive deliverances normally recorded in the New Testament.

Krick has responded that some people are delivered "in layers," either because multiple demons are involved or because a person has not yet completely surrendered. She has pointed to the healing of the blind man in Mark 8, where Jesus prayed twice before the man saw clearly.

Yet Mark 8 describes physical healing, not a doctrine of demons departing in layers. It does not establish a general pattern of Christians repeatedly requiring public exorcisms. Nor does it explain why dramatic manifestations themselves are so frequently treated as evidence that deliverance is occurring.

A responsible ministry should welcome careful documentation. When physical healing is claimed, medical verification should be encouraged where possible. When deliverance is claimed, there should be observable, lasting fruit--not merely another dramatic video.

Social media rewards spectacle. The church must not.

The Most Serious Concern: Money And Deliverance

The clearest theological warning involves Krick's teaching about "sowing" financially in connection with deliverance.

Krick has denied that people can simply purchase freedom. She has said that treating deliverance as a financial transaction would be unbiblical.

Yet teachings associated with her ministry appear to go considerably further than encouraging ordinary Christian generosity.

Krick has taught that when people or their ancestors have "sown into the devil's kingdom," giving money to God's kingdom can cause the consequences of that bondage to be removed more quickly. She has encouraged those facing intense spiritual attacks to "sow a seed" for the need and spoken of "sowing specific seeds for complete freedom." She has also suggested that the more people give to God, the more the devil must leave.

That language presents a profound pastoral danger.

The Bible encourages generous, joyful and sacrificial giving. But giving is never presented as a payment that increases the effectiveness of deliverance. Paul's teaching about sowing and reaping in 2 Corinthians 9 concerns generous support for ministry and care for believers--not purchasing freedom from demons.

Jesus told His disciples, "Freely you have received; freely give" when commissioning them to heal the sick and cast out demons. When Simon attempted to obtain spiritual power through money in Acts 8, Peter rebuked him severely.

Even when no explicit price is demanded, connecting financial giving with quicker freedom places enormous pressure on desperate people. A mother frightened for her child, a person tormented by anxiety or someone longing for healing may conclude that continued suffering means they have not given enough.

That is precisely why spiritual leaders must build an unmistakable wall between money and miracles.

This teaching requires more than clarification. It should be plainly renounced.

When Honor Begins To Resemble Devotion

Another concern involves the level of personal admiration reportedly directed toward Krick.

Footage has shown followers bowing, bringing gifts and referring to her in maternal terms such as "Mama", while expressing their love for her. Critics argue that such behavior can begin to resemble devotion that should be reserved for Christ.

Krick herself has taught that believers should look to Jesus rather than the human vessel. She has said there should be no glory or focus placed on her, although she also teaches that honoring anointed vessels is important for receiving more anointing.

The first statement is welcome. Yet leaders are responsible not only for what they say but for the culture they permit.

When Cornelius bowed before Peter, Peter immediately raised him up and said, "Stand up; I too am a man." When crowds attempted to treat Paul and Barnabas as gods, the apostles tore their garments and rushed into the crowd to stop them.

Faithful leaders do not merely insist that they are not being worshiped. They actively dismantle any atmosphere in which their presence, touch, approval or personal "anointing" becomes the center of Christian devotion.

No minister should become the indispensable doorway through which followers believe they must pass to reach God's power.

This standard does not apply only to charismatic ministries. Celebrity culture can form around any influential Christian leader. A gifted preacher, respected theologian, political commentator or bestselling author can become so closely identified with truth that followers begin defending the person rather than examining the teaching.

When loyalty to a leader makes honest questions feel like betrayal, something has gone wrong.

Discernment Is Not An Attack On The Holy Spirit

Christians should resist two equally harmful conclusions.

The first is that every unusual manifestation must be counterfeit. God remains sovereign. The Holy Spirit still convicts, comforts, empowers, heals and distributes gifts according to His will. We should pray expectantly and leave room for God to act beyond our routines.

The second is that questioning a claimed miracle amounts to resisting God.

Scripture never commands unquestioning acceptance of supernatural claims. It commands the opposite: "Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God" (1 John 4:1).

The questions surrounding Kathryn Krick's ministry are therefore not produced merely by hostility toward charismatic Christianity. Many believers who affirm healing, spiritual gifts and the present work of the Holy Spirit are nevertheless troubled by the apostolic claims, repeated public deliverances, leader-centered culture and teachings that connect financial sowing with spiritual freedom.

Calling the entire ministry a cult may go beyond what can be established from selected videos alone. But dismissing every concern as jealousy, religious opposition or resistance to revival would be equally irresponsible.

The same principle must be carried into every church and ministry. Christians should ask whether leaders teach the whole counsel of God, handle Scripture faithfully, practice financial transparency, welcome correction, protect vulnerable people and direct attention toward Christ rather than themselves.

Believers should also examine whether their loyalty is rooted in biblical truth or personal attachment. Would they recognize error if it came from a leader they deeply admired? Could they question a teaching without fearing spiritual retaliation? Are they being equipped to study Scripture for themselves, or trained to depend increasingly upon the leader's unique insight, authority or anointing?

Healthy Christian leadership does not produce spiritual dependency upon the leader. It helps believers mature into deeper dependency upon Christ.

The church does not need less of the Holy Spirit. It needs more of the true work of the Holy Spirit--a work that magnifies Christ, honors Scripture, protects

the vulnerable, welcomes accountability and produces lasting fruit.

Genuine revival does not fear examination.

It survives it.

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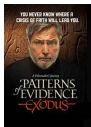
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